

Your Exercise Packet

Session 2 — "Claude that does the work" Searcy Chamber of Commerce · Thursday, August 20, 2026

By the end of today you'll be able to...

- Point Claude at a folder on your own computer and have it sort the whole thing out.
 - Turn a pile of receipts, scans, and notes into one finished spreadsheet or document.
 - Search your own email and get a reply drafted without leaving Claude.
 - Build one Skill — a job you do over and over, written down once, so you never explain it again.
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Before you start

You need three things:

1. **The Claude app on your computer**, signed in. Not the browser tab — the app you installed after last session. (Didn't get it installed? Go to **claude.ai/download** now. If it won't install today, say so — the browser at **claude.ai** covers this afternoon's email and Skills work, and you'll share a screen with a neighbour for the folder exercises.)
2. **Today's two downloads**, from the same short link as last time:

tinyurl.com/petalstem26

- `petal-and-stem-mess.zip` — Dana's folder of paperwork, 19 files
- `inbox-samples.zip` — 12 emails, only needed if your own email won't connect

Download the first one when E1 asks for it. Leave the second one alone unless you need it.

3. **One messy folder of your own**, and your **email password**.

How this packet works. Eight exercises, E1 through E8, in the order we'll do them. Each has a goal, numbered steps, and a bold **Done when** line so you always know whether you're finished. Your instructor will call time — if you're not done, that's fine. Nobody is behind. Every step is written down here, so you can finish anything at home.

About Dana. Same made-up flower shop as August 6: Petal & Stem, on Race Street, owned by Dana. Same supplier, and — you'll see — the same contract.

A word on words

Five new words today. That's all of them.

- **Cowork** — the mode where Claude works on real files in a folder you pick, instead of you uploading things one at a time. Same app, same account.

- **Connect a folder** — you choose one folder and give Claude permission to work in it. It cannot see anything outside that folder.
 - **Connector** — a door between Claude and something you already use: your email, your calendar, your file storage.
 - **Plugin** — a bundle of connectors and know-how for a kind of work, installed in one step instead of assembled piece by piece.
 - **Skill** — instructions for one job you do over and over, saved once. Claude picks it up on its own when that job comes around.
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The one rule for today

Point it at a copy.

Any folder of yours you hand to Claude today, **make a copy of it first**. Not because we expect a disaster — because a folder you copied is a folder you don't have to be nervous about, and nervous people don't try anything.

Block 1 — Point it at the mess

E1 — Let it clean out a folder

Goal: watch Claude sort out a folder where none of the filenames tell you what's inside.

Steps

1. Go to tinyurl.com/petalstem26 and download `petal-and-stem-mess.zip`.
2. **Unzip it.** This is the step everybody skips, and nothing works until you do it.
 - **Windows:** right-click the file, choose **Extract All**, then click **Extract**.
 - **Mac:** double-click the file.

You should end up with a *folder* named `petal-and-stem-mess` with 19 files inside it. If what you have still has a zipper on the icon, you're not there yet.

Put it somewhere you can find again — your Desktop or your Documents folder. You're about to have to point at it.

3. Open the **Claude app** and switch the message box from **Chat** to **Cowork**. It's the same box you've been typing into; there's a switch on it.
4. **Connect the folder.** Tell Cowork to work in the `petal-and-stem-mess` folder you just unzipped, and pick it in the folder chooser. **Claude will show you a card asking for access to that folder — approve it.** On a Mac, macOS may also ask once, separately; say yes to that too.

You are handing over **one folder**. Not your documents, not your desktop, not your computer. Claude cannot see anything outside it.

5. Type this (or paste it — either is fine):

```
This folder is eight months of paperwork from my flower shop and none of the filenames mean anything. Look at what's actually inside each file, then sort everything into folders that make sense for a small business. Rename anything whose name doesn't say what it is. Tell me what you're going to do before you do it.
```

6. **Let it work.** This takes a few minutes. That's normal — it's opening every file, including the photographs. It is not frozen. Don't retype.
7. It'll come back with a plan and wait for you. Read it, then approve it.
8. **Now go look.** Open that folder on your computer the normal way — File Explorer or Finder. That's the part that makes it real.

Done when: the folder on your computer is organized into sensible subfolders, and you can name one file whose new name tells you something the old name didn't.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *is there anything in this folder that looks like it needs my attention?* Hold onto what it says — you'll need it in E3.

E2 — Now your own folder

Goal: the same thing, on the mess you brought.

Steps

1. **Make a copy of your folder first.** Right-click it, **Copy**, then **Paste**. Let it be called "Copy of" whatever. **Point Claude at the copy.**
2. Connect that copy in Cowork, the same way you did in E1.
3. Ask for the same thing, about your folder — sort it out, rename what's badly named, and tell you the plan first.

Your call, and we mean it: if the folder you brought is your most sensitive one — client files, anything with account numbers in it — use a different folder today. Nothing here requires it.

Didn't bring a folder? Stay on Dana's and do the fast finisher below. You've missed nothing.

Huge folder? If yours has thousands of files, copy out a *piece* of it — one year, one client, one project — and use that.

Done when: Claude has proposed a structure for a folder of your own, and you've either approved it or decided you'd rather do it at home.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *what's in here that I've clearly got more than one copy of?* Duplicates are the easiest thing in the world to lose track of and the easiest thing for it to find.

Block 2 — Make something out of it

Block 1 was Claude *moving* things. This is Claude *making* things.

E3 — Turn a pile into a spreadsheet

Goal: get one real spreadsheet out of a stack of PDFs and two photographs, without opening a single one of them.

Steps

1. Stay in Cowork with the `petal-and-stem-mess` folder connected.
2. Type this:

Go through every invoice and receipt in this folder, including the photos, and build me one spreadsheet with a row for each one: date, who I paid, what it was for, and the amount. Add a total at the bottom. Save it in this folder as `expenses.xlsx`.

3. Let it run. Nine invoices and receipts, two of them photographs.
4. **Open the spreadsheet** — go to the folder on your computer and open `expenses.xlsx` in Excel or Numbers. It's a real file. You could email it to your accountant right now.
5. Now the good question:

Is there anything on these invoices I should be annoyed about?

6. Read that answer carefully. There is money in there that Dana has been paying without noticing — **about \$108** of it. See if you can say where it came from and when it started.

If you were here on August 6th, this one is going to be satisfying. That's the same supplier whose contract we read, and this is that contract actually charging her.

Done when: `expenses.xlsx` exists in the folder with a total in it, and you can say what the surcharge is and which month it started.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *what did I spend by month, and is anything trending up?* Or: *which supplier is most of my money?*

E4 — Make one finished document

Goal: turn scraps into something you could actually send someone.

Pick one.

Option A — Dana's (everybody can do this one):

Read my notes about the October 10th wedding and turn them into a written quote I could send to the customer. Save it as a Word document in this folder.

Option B — yours: point at a pile of your own — job notes, a stack of receipts, meeting scribbles — and ask for the finished thing you'd normally have to build by hand. An estimate, a summary, a report, a list.

Done when: a new file exists in the folder that you didn't write.

Fast finisher: Ask it to do it again in a different tone — *"more formal, this one's going to a bank"* — and watch how little you had to re-explain.

Do this at the break — connect your email

Two minutes, and the next block doesn't work without it.

If your email is Google (Gmail, or a Google Workspace address)

1. In the Claude app, click **Customize** in the **left sidebar**.
2. You'll see tabs: **Skills, Connectors, Plugins**. Click **Connectors**.
3. Find **Gmail** in the list and connect it. **No Gmail in the list at all?** That happens on some work accounts, where it has to be switched on for the whole company first. Use the practice inbox below — you're not missing anything today.
4. It'll send you to Google to sign in. Do that.
5. **Look at which Google account you're picking.** If you have a personal Gmail and a business one, this is the moment to get it right — Claude connects to the one account you choose.
6. Approve the permission screen.

If your email is Microsoft (Outlook, Office, a work address)

You're not connecting today, and it isn't anything you did. Microsoft requires the person who administers your company's email to approve Claude once, for everybody — that's a conversation, not a two-minute job at a break. And if your address ends in **@outlook.com**, **@hotmail.com**, or **@live.com**, there's no supported way to connect it at all.

Two things instead, and you lose nothing today:

1. **Use the practice inbox** — the fallback below. Every exercise in Block 3 works on it exactly the same way.
2. **Your homework sheet has a page you can forward to whoever runs your email.** That's the whole job.

Read this before you hit that permission screen. Google's approval screen mentions permission to *send* email. It looks alarming. Here's the truth: **Claude's Gmail connector has no send button at all.** It can write a draft and that's where it stops — every email is sent by you, by hand, out of your own Gmail. Google's screen is just written in broad strokes.

It's going to read your email. That part is true, and it's worth taking seriously. That's exactly why we're doing it here, together, instead of you clicking through it alone some evening.

Worth knowing while you decide: what Claude reads through a connector is not used to train Anthropic's models. Things you paste into a chat yourself are a separate question, and there's a setting for that under **Settings > Privacy**.

If your Google account won't connect — some work accounts block outside apps, and that's your IT department's setting, not anything you did — **use the fallback**, same as the Microsoft folks:

Download `inbox-samples.zip` from tinyurl.com/petalstem26, unzip it, and connect *that folder* in Cowork. Twelve emails out of Dana's inbox. Every exercise below works on it exactly the same way, and you're not missing a thing.

Done when: your email shows as connected under Customize > Connectors — or you've got the sample folder connected instead.

Block 3 — Let it into your inbox

The rule for this whole block

Nobody sends anything today. Drafts only.

E5 — Find things you forgot about

Goal: get answers out of the biggest unsorted pile you own.

Steps

1. Stay in Cowork. Ask these **one at a time**, reading each answer:

1. Search my email for anything from a supplier or vendor about a price increase this year. Tell me what you found and when it arrived.
2. What's in my inbox that I haven't answered and should have?
3. What needs a decision from me this week?

2. Sit with the second one for a second. Most people find something in there older than they'd like.

Using the sample folder instead? Ask the same three questions about "the emails in this folder." The answers are all in there — two price increases, and one customer who has been waiting since June 18th.

Done when: Claude has told you about at least one email you'd forgotten was sitting there.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *summarize everything from the last week as a short list of what needs a decision from me.* That's the one people are still using six months later.

E6 — Draft a reply (and don't send it)

Goal: get a real reply written, and practice the habit that keeps this safe.

Steps

1. Pick the oldest thing you haven't answered.
2. Ask for a draft — and **say the last part every single time:**

Draft a reply to [WHO]. [HOW IT SHOULD SOUND — warm, brief, apologetic, firm — your call.] Save it as a draft. Do not send it.

3. **Go find the draft in your actual email program.** Open Gmail or Outlook and look in your drafts folder. It's sitting there, unsent.
4. Read it. Fix the thing it got wrong — there's usually one.

5. **Leave it.** Send it later today if you want to, from your own hands.

Using the sample folder instead? Pick one of the twelve emails that needs an answer — Jenna, the unhappy customer, the funeral home — and ask for the reply the same way. Claude will write it out for you instead of putting it in a drafts folder. Same exercise, same habit.

Done when: there's a reply you didn't type — sitting in your drafts folder, or written out in front of you — and you've read it end to end.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *what did I not address in their email that I should have?* It's very good at catching the question you skipped.

Block 4 — Teach it a job once

On August 6 you taught Claude **who you are** — that was the Project, your business written down once.

Today you teach it **how you do one job**. That's a Skill. Same idea, applied to a procedure instead of a background: write it down once, and Claude picks it up whenever that job comes around.

E7 — Write down a job you repeat

Goal: turn something you explain over and over into something you never explain again.

Do steps 1 and 2 on paper before you touch the keyboard. Your instructor will give you three quiet minutes. Use them — this page is the part that matters, and it works whether or not the computer cooperates.

Steps

1. **Pick one job.** Small and specific beats big and impressive. Good ones:

- how you write a quote or an estimate
- what goes on your invoices, every time
- your weekly or monthly report
- the checklist you walk a new employee through
- how you answer a particular kind of customer question

Not "run my business." One job, with a beginning and an end.

2. **Fill these four in:**

THE JOB – what am I asking it to do?

WHEN – when should Claude use this? ("whenever I ask for a quote")

MY RULES – how I do it that nobody else would guess. Prices, markups, the lines I always include, the things I never say. Three to six of these.

1.

2.

3.

4.

DONE LOOKS LIKE – what's in the finished thing?

3. **Now type it.** In Cowork, tell Claude what you just wrote:

I want to make a skill for [THE JOB], so I never have to explain my format again. Here's how I do it: [YOUR RULES, in plain sentences]. When it's finished it should [DONE LOOKS LIKE]. Ask me anything you need, then build it.

4. **Answer its questions.** It'll ask a few. This is the easiest anyone has ever made writing down how you work.

If it offers to test the skill, run evaluations, or benchmark it, say no. That's a real feature built for programmers, and it will happily spend the rest of the session on it. The line to type:

Skip the evals, just make the skill.

5. **Turn it on.** Click **Customize** in the left sidebar, open the **Skills** tab, and check that your new skill is there and switched on. **That list is the answer** — if it's there with its toggle on, you're done.

If Claude hands you a file instead of installing it: in that same **Skills** tab, click the +, choose **Create skill**, then **Upload a skill**, and pick the file it gave you.

Done when: your skill is listed under **Customize > Skills** — or, if time ran out, the four blanks above are filled in. Either one is a win, and the second one takes ten minutes at home.

E8 — Run it, then fix it

Goal: see it fire on its own, and learn the one repair move.

Steps

1. Ask for the job **without mentioning the skill**:

```
[Write me a quote for... / Put together this week's report... /  
Whatever your job actually is.]
```

2. Watch what comes back. Did it follow your rules — your markup, your lines, your format? If yes: **it went and got its own instructions**. You never told it to.
3. **If it ignored the skill, start a new Cowork session and ask again first**. Skills load when a session *starts*, so one you saved a minute ago may not exist yet as far as this session is concerned. This fixes it more often than anything else.
4. **Still nothing?** Ask for it by name:

```
Use my [NAME] skill for this.
```

Then improve it so it fires on its own next time:

```
Update the skill's description so it gets used whenever I ask for  
something like this.
```

5. **Found something it got wrong?** Don't rewrite the whole thing. Just tell it:

```
Add this to the skill: [the thing it missed].
```

That's how you fix a skill for the rest of its life — the same way you'd fix a new employee. Once.

Done when: you've run your skill at least once and made one improvement to it.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *what else should be in this skill that I didn't think to tell you?* It'll ask about the cases you forgot — the rush job, the repeat customer, the one where you waive the deposit. Those answers are version two.

What you just did

Look back at the first page. That list is done:

- **Point Claude at a folder and have it sort the whole thing out** — E1, and again on your own folder in E2.

- **Turn a pile into one finished spreadsheet or document** — E3 built `expenses.xlsx` out of PDFs and photographs; E4 made a document out of scraps.
- **Search your email and get a reply drafted** — E5 and E6.
- **Build one Skill** — E7, and you ran and repaired it in E8.

Four things you couldn't do at 11:00.

Three habits to take home

August 6 gave you three habits about how to *talk* to it. These three are about what happens when it's doing the work instead of you.

Describe the outcome. Point it at a copy. Read it before it goes out.

- **Describe the outcome.** Not the steps. "Build me a spreadsheet of what I spent" — not "open this file, now copy that number." Every single thing that worked today, you described the end and let it find the middle.
- **Point it at a copy.** Always, until you're comfortable. It's free, it takes four seconds, and it's the difference between trying things and being careful.
- **Read it before it goes out.** Drafts are free. Sent is permanent.

If something goes sideways

What's happening	What to do
"It can't see my files"	The zip was never unzipped. Windows: right-click > Extract All . Mac: double-click. Then connect the <i>extracted folder</i> , not the zip.
Can't find Cowork	It's not a separate app. In the Claude app, use the switch on the message box to go from Chat to Cowork .
It's just sitting there	It isn't stuck. Cowork takes a minute or three because it's doing real work. Don't retype — you'll queue up two jobs.
It can't get into the folder	The permission box got dismissed. Disconnect the folder, connect it again, and say yes this time.
No spreadsheet or document got made	Initials (bottom-left) > Settings > Capabilities > turn on " Code execution and file creation. " Same switch as last session.
It put a table in the chat instead of making a file	Name the file: " <i>save it as expenses.xlsx in this folder.</i> "
Email won't connect	Work accounts often block outside apps — not your fault and not fixable today. Use <code>inbox-samples.zip</code> in Cowork instead; every exercise works on it.

What's happening	What to do
"It's asking to send my email!"	Google's approval screen is written broadly. Claude's Gmail connector cannot send . It writes drafts; you send them.
It can't read an attachment	It can see that an attachment is there, not what's in it. Save the attachment into your connected folder and ask about it there.
It can't find an email you know exists	It might be in Spam, which it can't see. Or describe the email instead of quoting it exactly.
Your skill didn't fire	Ask for it by name once, then tell it to improve the skill's description. That's the actual fix.
"I hit a usage limit"	Cowork uses more than chatting does. Check Settings > Usage . Everything here is written down — finish it tonight.
You're behind	You're not. Every step is in this packet and it's yours to keep.

Keep this packet. Everything in it works the same way at your desk next week as it did in this room today. If you lose it, this packet, the cheat sheet, and the homework are all at tinyurl.com/petalstem26 — the same link the sample files came from.

The homework is three small things before September 10.